

Fractured Trust: The Spillover Effects of Police Violence on Satisfaction with Democracy and Political Trust

ANONYMISED AUTHOR(S) *Anonymised Institution(s)*

How does police violence impact citizens' satisfaction with democracy? This paper explores how police violence against civilians influences citizens' satisfaction with democracy through its effect on trust in institutions. To examine the effects of direct and indirect police violence, we conducted two studies: an experimental study in Brazil and an observational analysis using LAPOP data across various Latin American countries. Our results reveal that both direct experiences of police violence and indirect exposure significantly erode trust in key democratic institutions, including the judiciary, legislature, and executive. This erosion of political trust is mediated through increased distrust in the police and negative perceptions of procedural justice. Additionally, the effects of indirect exposure are moderated by factors such as race, partisan identity, and predisposition to aggression. Overall, this research underscores the critical impact of police violence on political trust and emphasizes that addressing such violence is crucial for sustaining democratic legitimacy, particularly in regions facing democratic backsliding. By highlighting the broader political consequences of police violence, our study contributes to the literature on political behavior and public opinion while suggesting law enforcement reforms to strengthen democracy's resilience.

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INTRODUCTION

Police violence is a persistent issue in Latin America, where law enforcement has been involved in activities such as unlawful killings, torture, monetary extortion, and collaboration with criminal organizations (Brinks 2007). Reports from Bolivia, Honduras, Colombia, Argentina, El Salvador, and Peru, among other countries, highlight widespread misconduct (Human Rights Watch, 2020). In Chile, police killed at least 31 civilians and injured approximately 3,000 during the 2019 protests (Dammert and Sazo 2020). In Brazil, police killings have exceeded 6,000 per year since 2018 (Bueno and de Lima 2019, 2023). Despite democratization, police and military

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forces retain significant power and influence. In this context, it is important to learn whether exposure to police violence can influence citizens' evaluation of democracy and their trust in its institutions.

Here, we ask whether citizens' experiences with police violence influence their satisfaction with democracy and trust in its institutions. Systematic police violence undermines democratic principles by violating equal citizenship, breaking the rule of law, and eroding perceptions of procedural justice (Bonner 2021; González 2020; Wiatrowski 2016; Manning 2015). These violations weaken trust in institutions and shape citizens' evaluations of the democratic system's effectiveness and fairness. Research shows that police violence reduces cooperation with law enforcement (McLean et al. 2024; Droic and Shoub 2024; Ang et al., 2021; Carr et al. 2007). It also influences political behavior by mobilizing some citizens, particularly in marginalized communities (Reid 2024; Morris and Shoub 2024; Ang and Tebes 2024), shifting policy preferences (Mullinix et al. 2021; Culhane et al. 2016), and shaping perceptions of political efficacy (Branton et al. 2023), highlighting its consequences on democracy.

Satisfaction with democracy is a widely studied measure of system legitimacy (Valgarðsson and Devine, 2021). Research has identified several key predictors of this attitude, including economic expectations, socioeconomic status, education, interpersonal trust, crime victimization, government efficacy, and perceived income fairness (Monsiváis-Carrillo and Cantú Ramos 2022; Kriekhaus et al. 2014; Evans and Rose 2012; Fernandez and Kuenzi 2010; Mishler and Rose 1996). However, existing research has largely overlooked whether police violence, as an institution of the state, affects democratic satisfaction.

Studying the impact of police violence is particularly important in Latin America, where democracies are often described as 'uncivil democracies' (Holston and Caldeira 1998). Although political rights such as voting are established, pervasive violence, impunity, and corrupt judicial systems hinder the full realization of civil rights (Pereira and Davis 2000). Despite the police's central role in society, analyses of politics and opinion about democracy in the region often overlook their influence. Instead, scholarly attention tends to focus on state, military, and criminal violence when examining political behavior and attitudes (e.g., Chouhy et al. 2022; Gomes and Alves de Aquino 2018; Trelles and Carreras 2012). In this paper, we theorize that exposure to and victimization by police violence will erode satisfaction

with democracy and trust in political institutions.

We test our theory in three studies. In the first study, an original two-wave vignette experiment in Brazil isolates indirect exposure to police violence, the kind that reaches most citizens through media coverage. Next, we turn to the 2019 Chilean *estallido social*, where police repression fell on some census zones and not others, and we ask whether residents exposed to that shock diverged from residents of comparable zones. Finally, we use LAPOP survey data across sixteen Latin American countries to examine direct victimization by the police and to test whether the pathway we theorize appears in the cross-national record.

In Study 1, participants who read a vignette depicting a violent police encounter reported lower trust in the police and lower satisfaction with democracy than those who read a non-violent scenario, while the effect on political trust emerged mainly among non-whites, respondents who like the PT, and individuals high in trait aggression, the groups in which every effect concentrated. In Study 2, living in an exposed zone eroded trust in political institutions and satisfaction with democracy, and it did so independently of the nationwide collapse in police trust that followed the repression. In Study 3, respondents who report police abuse show lower trust in the police, lower political trust, and lower satisfaction with democracy across all sixteen countries, and the association between police abuse and dissatisfaction runs mainly through political trust rather than through trust in the police directly.

To our knowledge, this is the first study to theorize and examine the effect of exposure to police violence on trust in democratic institutions within a single framework. In a period of concern over democratic backsliding, our study argues for treating police violence as more than a human rights violation. It also threatens democratic legitimacy through negative spillover onto citizens' trust in the institutions democracy rests on and their satisfaction with the system.

THE SPILLOVER EFFECTS OF POLICE VIOLENCE

The police are a physical embodiment of state authority and, as such, probably the most visible state institution to most ordinary citizens. As a street-level bureaucratic organization, the police deliver policy in the everyday lives of the citizens they are meant to serve (Brodin 2011). In many places they are the most proximate face of the state, especially in small towns and villages where institutions such

as the Judiciary and the Legislature are absent. This visibility is what leads us to ask whether police violence negatively affects broader public opinion about democracy and its institutions.

One crucial distinction the police have over other street-level bureaucrats is that they are *armed*. They carry the legal right to use coercive power to fulfill their mandate, and citizens expect them to apply force proportionately, practically, and appropriately (Kleinig 2014). Following Milani et al. (2018), we define police violence as the excessive and needless use of physical force in police-citizen encounters, where “excessive” refers to force disproportionate to what a given situation requires. This definition also extends more broadly to include psychological, sexual, and neglectful harm, consistent with the World Health Organization’s classification of violence (Cooper et al. 2004). Incidents of such violence against citizens have provoked contentious public debate and a growing literature on policing. These experiences weaken citizens’ assessment of procedural justice—the fairness of process and treatment, rather than outcomes (Tyler and Allan Lind 2001), and foster more negative attitudes toward law enforcement, including distrust and perceptions of inefficacy (e.g., Branton et al. 2023; Jackson et al. 2021; Boudreau et al. 2019). That skepticism, in turn, reduces civilian cooperation with local police and local government, lowering, for example, willingness to call the police (McLean et al. 2024; Drolc and Shoub 2024; Carr et al. 2007).

This dynamic should be particularly pronounced in Latin America, where the police have run drug operations, committed killings, kidnappings, torture, extorted money, supplied intelligence to criminal organizations, and mistreated detainees (Brinks 2007). Despite democratization, the military and the police retain significant power in many countries, and law enforcement has itself grown more militarized (Sung et al. 2022). Public confidence in the police is low across the region: most citizens report dissatisfaction with police performance, and only small minorities consider the police well trained or credit them with improving on human rights (Pion-Berlin and Carreras 2017). Studying police violence becomes especially important here, in democracies often described as “uncivil” (Holston and Caldeira 1998), where political rights such as voting are established, but pervasive violence, impunity, and corrupt judicial systems block the full realization of civil rights (Pereira and Davis 2000).

A large body of work connects contact with police violence to public opinion and political behavior. Mullinix et al. (2021) and Culhane et al. (2016) show that exposure to police violence through text,

audio, or video can increase support for policy changes such as mandatory body cameras. On the perceived value of democratic participation, Branton et al. (2023) finds that exposure to police violence lowers beliefs about the external efficacy of voting and protesting. Attitudes toward police violence, however, can be polarized along ideological and partisan lines. In Latin America, high criminal violence pressures governments to act, and because public security remains a core state responsibility, many citizens, particularly on the right, embrace *mano dura* (iron-fist) policing, framing aggressive enforcement as a function of a strong state and tolerating or endorsing violence against perceived criminals. The pattern holds globally. In the United States, policing attitudes split sharply by ideology, with conservatives holding stable or positive views of law enforcement while liberals show greater concern about misconduct (Reny and Newman 2021), and support for harsh policing tracks authoritarianism among populist bases of leaders such as Donald Trump and Jair Bolsonaro (Vidigal 2022; Knuckey and Hassan 2022; Womick et al. 2018), sometimes surfacing only among citizens on the ideological right (Cohen and Smith 2016).

Effects on behavior are more mixed and often racialized. Morris and Shoub (2024) and Ang and Tebes (2024) find that police killings mobilize voter registration and turnout in Black and Hispanic communities, while Markarian (2023) observes a localized drop in Black turnout within a mile of an incident, and Laniyonu (2018) finds lower participation in more-exposed communities in the United Kingdom, again moderated by race. On vote choice, in the United States, Reid (2024) finds that voters in areas with recent police killings favored the Democratic candidate in 2020, net of the usual predictors. Race structures these effects because policing is itself racialized in most contexts, where marginalized racial groups are disproportionately profiled (e.g., French 2013; Greenwald et al. 2003; Correll et al. 2002) and victimized (e.g., Bueno and de Lima 2023; Buehler 2017). Non-white individuals encounter police violence directly or through others in their community, so repeated exposure activates negative perceptions that shape their civic and political action more than among white individuals, who are both less victimized and less behaviorally responsive to these incidents (Morris and Shoub 2024; Crabtree and Yadon 2022; Ang and Tebes 2024).

Importantly, systemic and excessive police violence is in tension with democratic principles, so it can degrade citizens' perceptions of how well democracy serves its citizens. We distinguish

democratic evaluations as either normative or instrumental. Normative judgments stem from an intrinsic valuation of democracy and its core principles, such as cherishing free speech or equality before the law. Instrumental evaluations treat democracy as a tool for delivering outcomes such as economic growth or social inclusion. Police violence cuts against both. It directly violates core democratic principles, turning institutions meant to protect citizens into sources of fear and departing from the state's obligation to safeguard its citizens. When violence is produced, or not stopped, by a street-level bureaucratic organization, this signals that the system fails to deliver the outcomes citizens expect of it.

Here, we argue that police violence also shapes public opinion about democracy, as it can foster distrust in democratic institutions, and procedural justice underpins that link because it turns on four features of citizens' interactions with authorities: being treated with dignity and respect, having a voice, facing neutral and transparent decisions, and encountering trustworthy motives (Hough et al. 2017; Tyler 2003). More broadly, procedural justice is crucial for maintaining legitimacy, trust, and public confidence in democracy (Saxton 2021; Magalhães and Aguiar-Conraria 2019; Grimes 2017; Magalhães 2014). Violence by law enforcement violates procedural justice, and thereby breeds distrust. It weakens confidence in the rule of law and, by extension, the Judiciary, as citizens conclude that officials are not held accountable or bound by the same constraints as ordinary people.

As a spillover effect, then, we expect police performance to influence the evaluations of the state as a whole. Silva et al. (2022), for instance, find that exposure to police violence lowers trust in *local* government. But the spillover should not stop at local government. The police are the everyday embodiment of state authority, but the police sometimes *are* the state, especially where other democratic institutions are absent from daily life, and a citizen has no more tangible institution against which to judge the wider system. A violent encounter therefore updates beliefs not about one agency but about the fairness and trustworthiness of the state that arms and authorizes that agency. And because marginalized groups are disproportionately targeted, it is their belief in a biased system that attaches most strongly to the justice and legislative institutions charged with equality before the law. Police violence thus travels from the most visible arm of the state to the abstract national institutions.

Police violence can also degrade evaluations of democracy by threatening citizens' psychological and basic needs (DeVylder et al. 2017; Geller et al. 2014). Abusive practices conflict with the fun-

damental need for respect, inclusion, and dignity, undermining a sense of belonging and self-worth. Because this violence falls disproportionately on communities marginalized on racial, ethnic, or socioeconomic grounds, it intensifies inequality and pushes those communities out of economic and social life (DeVylder et al. 2017). Such violence leaves these communities materially and psychologically worse off, delivering the opposite of what a state is meant to provide for its citizens.

Despite these consequences, the role of police violence in shaping public opinion about democracy remains underexplored. The literature has extensively examined how economic expectations, socioeconomic status, education, interpersonal trust, government efficacy, and perceived income fairness, among many others, shape opinions about democracy and its institutions (e.g., Krieckhaus et al. 2014; Fernandez and Kuenzi 2010; Mishler and Rose 1996). Yet, when studying the effects of violence in Latin America, researchers tend to focus on state, military, and criminal violence while overlooking the police (e.g., Chouhy et al. 2022; Gomes and Alves de Aquino 2018; Trelles and Carreras 2012).¹

In this paper, we argue that assessments of public opinion about democracy and its institutions should also account for experiences of police violence. These experiences erode citizens' perceptions of procedural justice, which in turn breeds distrust in democratic institutions and shapes their broader evaluations of democracy.

SATISFACTION WITH DEMOCRACY AND TRUST IN ITS INSTITUTIONS

Citizens' assessment of and satisfaction with democracy depend on how they evaluate the system's effectiveness in upholding core democratic norms and its performance in meeting their needs (Canache et al. 2001). Conceptually, satisfaction with democracy indicates a mid-level support for the democratic system. Easton (1965, 1975) originally distinguished diffuse support, directed at the political community and the regime, from specific support, targeted at political authorities. Norris (1999) refined this scheme into evaluations of political actors, regime institutions, regime performance, regime principles, and the political community. Satisfaction with democracy sits at the level of regime performance, a middle tier

¹See Cruz (2015) for an exception.

of support between specific support for actors and institutions and support for the regime's principles, such as democracy itself (Norris 1999).

As an instrumental evaluation, satisfaction with democracy is influenced by many factors related to system performance (Singh and Mayne 2023). For instance, citizens who hold positive economic expectations, enjoy higher status, or see the income distribution as fair report more satisfaction (Loveless and Binelli 2020; Krieckhaus et al. 2014), and it also rises when citizens perceive the government as efficient and delivering on its promises, since this signals that the system is working and meeting their needs (Linde and Dahlberg 2021; Magalhães 2014).

Satisfaction with democracy has long predicted many political behaviors and attitudes across countries. Although evidence on its correlation with self-reported political participation is mixed (Singh and Mayne 2023), recent research in Mexico finds a positive correlation between satisfaction with democracy and administratively measured behaviors—turnout, training as a poll-worker, and staffing a polling station on Election Day (Vargas et al. 2026). Dissatisfaction can also shape vote choice, making citizens more likely to support populist parties of both the radical right and left (Ramiro 2016; Arzheimer 2009; Lubbers et al. 2002). In Latin America, satisfaction with democracy is often found to be positively correlated with support for democracy (Walker and Kehoe 2013; Sarsfield and Echegaray 2006). Claassen (2020) further finds that satisfaction is positively associated with subsequent change in democracy within democracies, where a one-standard-deviation rise in satisfaction predicts roughly one additional point in a country's V-Dem score the following year².

Trust in democratic institutions is the other face of these evaluations, conceptually aligned with system support for actors and institutions (Easton 1965, 1975; Norris 1999). Where satisfaction with democracy gauges how well the system works in practice, trust registers whether the institutions that run it are seen as legitimate and fair, and we argue the two move together. Citizens who judge institutional processes as fair extend both specific support to particular authorities and diffuse support to the system itself (Hetherington 1998). Procedural justice is what maintains legitimacy and public confidence in democracy (Saxton 2021; Magalhães and Aguiar-Conraria 2019; Grimes 2017; Magalhães 2014),

²Once support for democracy enters the model, satisfaction's statistical significance vanishes while support retains its own, suggesting that the standalone association reflects satisfaction proxying for principled support rather than any independent effect of performance evaluations.

and it is precisely the channel through which experiences with the state's most present institution, the police, reach citizens' evaluations of broader institutions.

Overall, because police violence can diminish both the normative and the instrumental evaluations of the democratic system, we hypothesize the following:

- **Main Hypothesis:** *Police violence will negatively affect satisfaction with democracy and trust in its institutions.*

STUDY 1: BRAZIL'S EXPERIMENT

To test our theory, we conducted an original two-wave online survey vignette experiment in Brazil³. Fieldwork was done throughout October 2023, and 1,004 respondents completed the first wave, and 624 completed both waves. We contracted Opinion Box, an online sample recruiter, to recruit subjects and conduct the study using the Qualtrics platform. We chose Brazil as a key case for studying the effects of police violence because of the high number of incidents and of its complex social and political dynamics.

The number of police killings in the country has been over six thousand a year since 2018, with 6,429 deaths in 2022 (Bueno and de Lima 2019, 2023). Individuals belonging to non-white racial groups disproportionately experience the impacts of police misconduct. The average percentage of fatal victims who were identified as white was approximately 19.5 from 2018 to 2022 (Bueno and de Lima 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023)⁴, which makes police violence a racialized issue in the country. For this reason, we pre-registered race as one of the possible moderators of the effects of exposure to police violence on satisfaction with democracy and political trust.

Brazil's political dynamics around police violence are also polarized. In July 2023, São Paulo, the most densely populated state in the country, saw a police operation launched in response to the killing of an officer in the region. Within a month, it had escalated into an extreme case of police violence, with 28 killings (Human Rights Watch 2023). Tarcísio de Freitas, the right-wing State

³Our experimental hypotheses were pre-registered, anonymized materials are in the Supplementary Information (SI).

⁴White Brazilians represent 43.5% of the population, according to the 2022 Census.

Governor at the time and an ally of far-right former President Jair Bolsonaro, described himself as “extremely satisfied” with the operation, even as residents of the region alleged summary executions and torture of non-criminals. The governor’s reaction was not an isolated stance but part of a broader right-wing trend that took hold with Jair Bolsonaro’s rise to the presidency in 2019, which brought a surge in right-wing populism alongside growing public support for the police and military. Bolsonaro, a former army captain, folded military personnel into his government, including a high-ranking officer as vice-president, and consistently promoted the armed forces’ perceived morality and efficiency. That endorsement extended to the police as well, both through their military branch and through a persistent narrative that a strong police presence was essential to ending criminal violence (Watmough 2021). Freitas’s continued support for police killings after Bolsonaro left office shows the durability of the defense of *mano dura*. Given this rhetoric, we also exploratorily examine Bolsonarismo (support for Bolsonaro) and dislike of Bolsonaro as possible moderators.

Additionally, we pre-registered support for (*Petismo*) and opposition to (*antipetismo*) the left-wing Workers’ Party (*Partido dos Trabalhadores*, PT) as a moderator, since these two identities anchor Brazil’s political polarization. Identification with the PT has been the most—and arguably the only—stable partisan identity in the country for nearly three decades (Carreirão and Rennó 2018; Baker et al. 2016; Samuels 2006), and the party’s perceived failures, including corruption scandals and economic crises, have also driven widespread disaffection among voters (Samuels and Zucco 2018).

Drawing from political psychology, among other possible traits, we chose to pre-register trait aggression personality as a possible moderator of the reactions to these violent events, particularly due to its effects on eliciting strong emotional responses to violence. The trait aggression personality battery measures people’s aggressive tendencies in everyday life (Buss and Perry 1992). Individuals with high levels of aggression exhibit a pronounced sensitivity to injustices, responding not with mere disapproval but with intense moral outrage. This reaction is deeply rooted in the aggressive person’s inherent predisposition towards hostility in the face of perceived threats or violations of justice (Kalmoe 2013). When exposed to incidents of police brutality, aggressive individuals are likely to experience a stronger reaction, perceiving these events as not only violations of individual rights but also as emblematic of broader systemic failures.

Having laid out the theoretical rationale for our moderators, we now turn to how the study was designed to capture their effects. In the first wave of Study 1, we measured baseline levels of our outcome variables and our moderators—race, political attachments, and trait aggression⁵. One week after completing the first wave, respondents were re-contacted to complete wave 2, in which they were randomly assigned to read one of the two vignettes. They later answered our outcome variable questions, constituting items about perceptions of procedural justice in the context of the situation described in the vignette (respect, voice, transparency, trustworthiness), one item related to trust in the police, three items related to trust in democratic institutions or “political trust” (trust in Congress, the Presidency, and the Judiciary), and one item tapping on subjects’ satisfaction with democracy.

There were two conditions within our manipulation: excessive police violence ($\text{violence}_i = 1$) and a non-violent policing scenario ($\text{violence}_i = 0$). The vignettes were summarized news articles describing an interaction between police officers and a middle-aged man during a traffic stop. The treatment with excessive police violence presents a scenario that escalates to violence when the man has a hard time finding his identification, resulting in an officer shooting the civilian in the leg. Conversely, the non-violent condition describes an appropriate interaction between the person and the police officers, where the person, though nervous, eventually finds his identification with no intervention from the officers.

We employ the Two-Way Fixed Effects (TWFE) estimator to assess the impact of this exposure to police violence. We define the treatment variable $D_{it} = \text{violence}_i \times \text{Post}_t$, where $\text{Post}_t = 1$ for observations from wave 2 and $\text{Post}_t = 0$ for wave 1 data. Consequently, $D_{it} = 0$ for all participants in wave 1, and $D_{it} = 1$ for those randomly assigned to the police violence vignette condition during wave 2. Through randomization in the second wave, we ensure that individuals are comparable across both waves in terms of their pre-treatment characteristics and attitudes. Therefore, our design corresponds to a pre-post between-subjects experiment. The Average Treatment Effect (ATE) of interest can be conceptually illustrated as follows:

$$\text{ATE} = (\bar{Y}_{\text{wave}=2, \text{violence}=1} - \bar{Y}_{\text{wave}=1, \text{violence}=1}) - (\bar{Y}_{\text{wave}=2, \text{violence}=0} - \bar{Y}_{\text{wave}=1, \text{violence}=0}) .$$

⁵We also measured other demographics, political interest, turnout, and vote choice in the last presidential election.

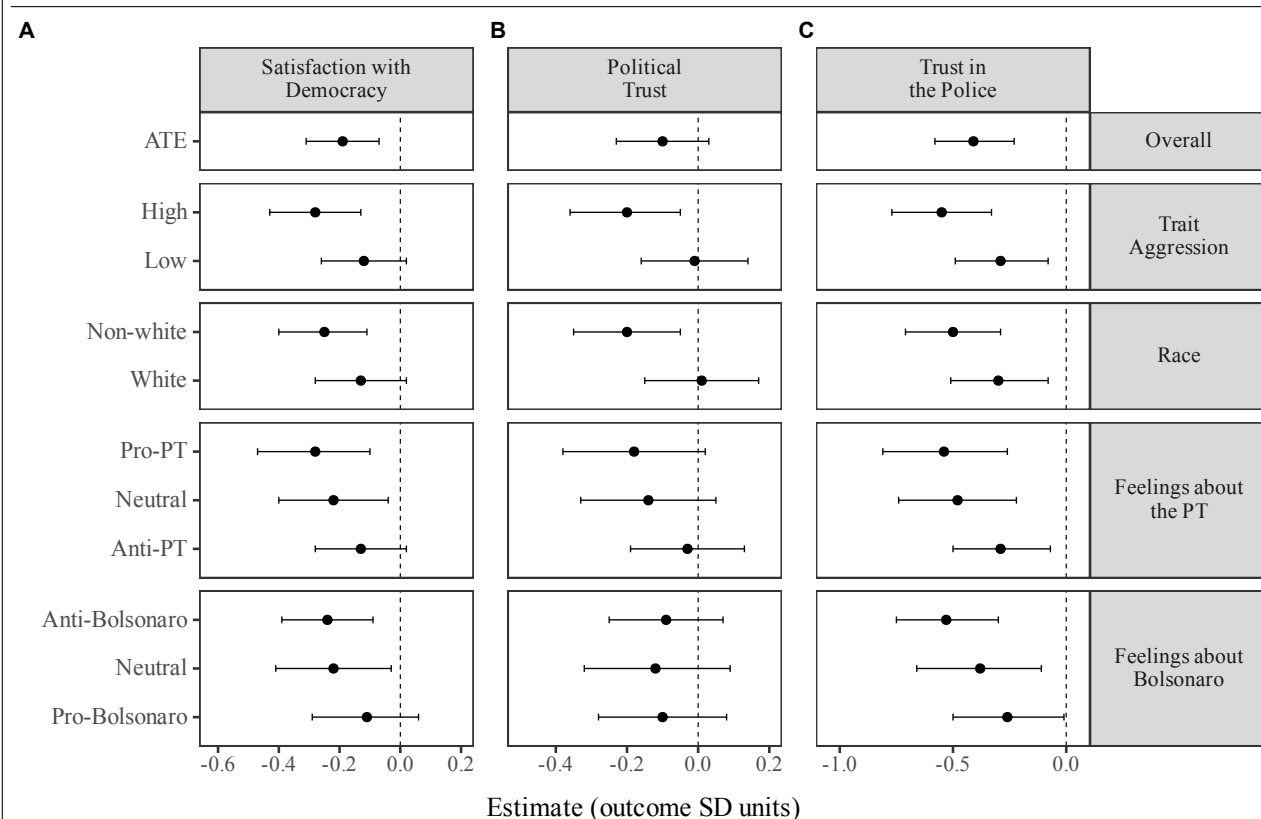
To further investigate heterogeneity in treatment effects, following our theoretical predictions, we calculate Conditional Average Treatment Effects (CATE) by interacting D with one moderator at a time: feelings about the PT (pro-PT for a 4 or 5 on the five-point party item, neutral for a 3, anti-PT for a 1 or 2, with nobody dropped), a non-white dummy, and a high trait aggression disposition (trait aggression scale > median).⁶

The full regressions, including the overall ATE in the full sample and the CATEs, are reported in Table A1 in the SI. The ATE results indicate a significant negative impact of indirect exposure to police violence on both satisfaction with democracy, at -0.194 (SE 0.061, $p < .001$), and trust in the police, at -0.405 (SE 0.089, $p < .001$). However, we do not find substantial evidence that the treatment directly and unconditionally influenced political trust (-0.099 , SE 0.064, $p = .062$).

As shown in Figure 1, the treatment increased distrust in the police in every subgroup. Because our hypotheses are directional, we report one-sided tests wherever a direction was registered in advance, and two-tailed tests for the Bolsonaro comparisons, for which none was. The contrast of interest is between pro-PT and anti-PT respondents. The effect is nearly twice as large in the first group, -0.535 (SE 0.138) against -0.285 (SE 0.112), with $p = .052$ for the difference, and the differences by trait aggression ($p = .017$) and by race ($p = .049$) run the same way. For political trust, the treatment left whites, anti-PT respondents, and individuals with low trait aggression unaffected. It was negative for pro-PT respondents (-0.180 , SE 0.100, $p = .036$), non-whites (-0.201 , SE 0.077, $p = .005$), and aggressive individuals (-0.204 , SE 0.081, $p = .006$). For satisfaction with democracy, the effect is negative in every subgroup and largest among pro-PT respondents (-0.284 , SE 0.095, $p = .001$). Its between-group differences are smaller, at $p = .067$ for feelings about the PT, $p = .029$ for trait aggression, and $p = .079$ for race.

Finally, in the SI, we include a table with estimates for the treatment groups on the items measuring perceptions of procedural justice, which we treat as a manipulation check. We find that perceptions of procedural justice regarding the behavior of the police officers in the violent vignette strongly erode perceptions of procedural justice in contrast to the non-violent vignette.

⁶Please refer to the SI for the construction of these scales. Feelings about Bolsonaro, measured the same way on a matching item, appear as an exploratory fifth panel of Figure 1; that moderator was not pre-registered.

FIGURE 1. Treatment Effects

Note: A five-point item asks about the Workers' Party, running from 1, I hate the party, to 5, I am a petista. The pro-PT group answered 4 or 5, the neutral group answered 3, and the anti-PT group answered 1 or 2; every respondent is sorted and nobody is dropped. The Bolsonaro panel sorts the same way on a matching item about Bolsonaro. Each panel reads its own item alone; nothing is combined across items. High trait aggression is a score above the sample median on the twelve-item Buss and Perry battery, with each item rescaled 0 to 1 and summed. Non-white respondents did not report their race as white (*branca*). The anti-PT group is the omitted one in the PT panel and the pro-Bolsonaro group is the omitted one in the Bolsonaro panel. All outcomes are standardised, so estimates are in standard deviations.

The results provide substantial evidence for our theoretical framework and previous research. Exposure to a police violence scenario sharply reduces trust in the police and lowers satisfaction with democracy. Its effect on political trust points the same way but is indistinguishable from zero overall, surfacing only among non-whites, pro-PT respondents, and individuals high in trait aggression, the groups in which every effect concentrates. Perceptions of police violence thus erode democratic attitudes, most visibly where citizens are primed to register it, though the conditional effects across race, partisanship, and aggression rest on weaker evidence.

STUDY 2: CHILEAN SHOCKS

Study 1 showed that exposure to police violence, manipulated within a controlled vignette experiment, reduces trust in the police and satisfaction with democracy. Study 2 asks whether the same mechanism holds when exposure is not a hypothetical scenario but actual, geographically bounded episodes of police violence, in a country where such abuse is rare. We turn to Chile, where the 2019 *estallido social* produced a natural experiment: government repression of protesters generated documented human rights violations concentrated in specific census zones, exposing some residents directly while leaving residents of otherwise similar zones untouched. We test whether this real-world shock produced the same erosion in political trust and democratic satisfaction found in Study 1, using panel survey data linked to geocoded violence records. First, Chile's low pre-2019 baseline of police violence—unlike Brazil's chronic pattern—lets us observe how respondents react when police abuse arrives as a rupture rather than a routine feature of daily life. Second, because exposure here is observed rather than assigned, the design captures residents' actual experience of an unanticipated shock, an ecological validity no survey vignette can replicate.

That shock began on October 18, 2019, when a student-led campaign against a metro fare increase ignited the largest wave of protests in Chile in 30 years. High school students organized mass fare evasions, sit-ins, and demonstrations across Santiago. Within days, the movement expanded nationwide, culminating in over a million Chileans marching in Santiago and hundreds of thousands more joining protests across the country. The government at the time, led by right-wing President Sebastián Piñera, responded with unprecedented police and military repression, deploying armed soldiers and tanks to

the streets, resembling the repression of Pinochet's dictatorship (1973-1990). State forces used tear gas, rubber bullets, and live ammunition to disperse crowds, using force against civilians regardless of their involvement in the protests. Within weeks, reports of severe human rights violations emerged, including arbitrary arrests, torture, sexual violence, and mutilations caused by rubber bullets, with hundreds of protesters suffering permanent eye injuries (Bonner and Dammert 2022). Social media and independent press captured harrowing images of law enforcement officers violently confronting unarmed civilians. Between October and December 2019, at the height of the *estallido social*, violence from the police and the military resulted in at least 31 deaths, roughly 3,000 injuries, and roughly 20,000 arrests (Dammert and Sazo 2020).

The year before the *estallido social*, there were no reported cases of arbitrary or unlawful killings by government agents (United States Department of State 2019). Reports of torture and other cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment were also rare. This pattern aligns with the historical Chilean trend after the end of the dictatorship in 1990, in which police violence has been less common than in other Latin American countries. Against this baseline, the *estallido social* marks a sharp break from Chile's pre-2019 pattern, producing the zone-level police violence events this study treats as shocks.

We estimate the impact of these events on political trust and democratic satisfaction using panel data from the Longitudinal Social Study of Chile (ELSOC), an ongoing survey fielded annually since 2016. Our analytical sample focuses on the first four waves (2016–2019), capturing respondent attitudes before and immediately following the *estallido social*. Each respondent is geocoded to their residential census zone (*zona censal*), and zone identifiers are merged with geo-referenced police violence records from the National Institute of Human Rights (INDH). The INDH registry documents 2,832 victims logged between October 2019 and March 2020, 88.1% of them reporting physical-injury consequences, including 153 cases of ocular trauma, 32 of them resulting in irreversible vision loss (Instituto Nacional de Derechos Humanos 2020).⁷ A respondent is treated ($D_z = 1$) if INDH records a documented case of police violence in their own census zone on or before their Wave 4 interview date, and untreated ($D_z = 0$) otherwise. Standard errors are clustered at the census zone level to reflect the spatial unit of treatment assignment.

⁷The SI (Study 2) provides the full breakdown by violation type, instrument, and consequence.

Police violence during the *estallido* did not fall randomly across Chile. The municipalities most likely to register a documented violation were often the sites of the heaviest protest. Comparing exposed and unexposed zones within them would confound the effect of repression with the effect of the unrest that drew it. We therefore separate municipalities by their 2019 protest volume: those where protest did not surge above their own historical range, and those where it did.⁸ A third difference then asks whether the response to exposure differs between them:

$$y_{it} = \sum_{\tau \in \{2016, 2017, 2019\}} [\beta_{\tau} + \delta_{\tau} \mathbf{1}[S_c \geq 1]] (D_z \times \mathbf{1}[t = \tau]) + \alpha_i + \gamma_{ct} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

Here D_z marks a respondent's census zone as exposed, and S_c measures a municipality's 2019 protest volume against its own pre-period baseline in standard deviations. The term α_i absorbs everything fixed about a respondent, and γ_{ct} absorbs everything that moved a whole municipality in a given year. Three quantities follow. The first, β_{2019} , is the effect of exposure where protest did not surge. The second, δ_{2019} , is how much that effect differs where it did. Their sum is the implied effect in the municipalities that surged. We take 2018 as the reference year, which leaves 2016 and 2017 as placebos. No zone is exposed before 2019, so those coefficients ask whether zones that would later be exposed were already drifting apart from the rest—not whether an existing treatment had an effect. Where that joint test raises concern, we adjust for differential trends using each respondent's own baseline value of the outcome. We keep the adjusted version only when it both raises the joint p -value and shrinks the pre-period coefficients.

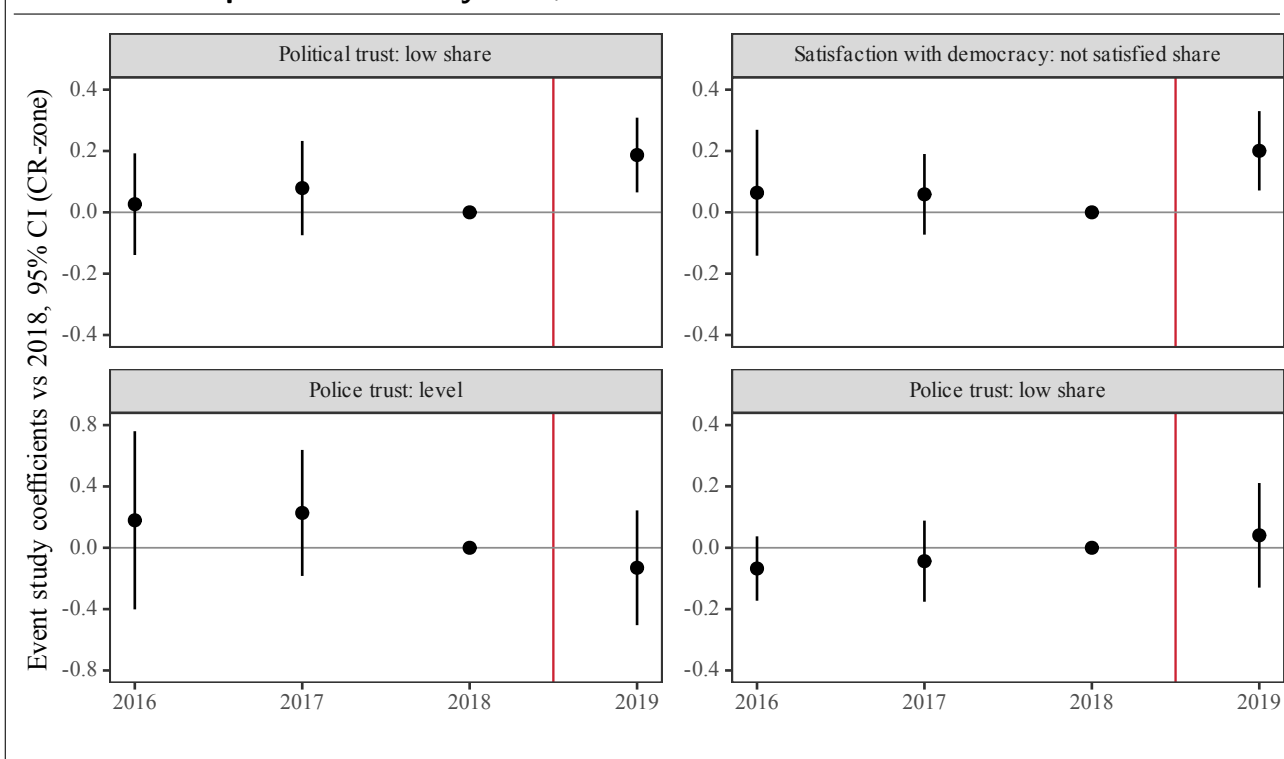
Table 1 reports the results; p -values in Studies 2 and 3 are two-tailed. Where protest did not surge, exposure raises the share of respondents who report no trust in political institutions by 0.187 (SE 0.062,

⁸ S_c is a municipality's 2019 protest activity minus its own pre-period mean, divided by its own pre-period standard deviation. Protest activity is the asinh-transformed sum of COES-recorded event sizes in a municipality-year, so it measures attendance rather than a count of events. The pre-period runs 2009–2018 with 2011 removed, since the student-movement cycle that year raises most municipalities' baseline and would shrink every surge score measured against it. The partition falls at one standard deviation, and it is lopsided: 75 of the 90 municipalities with a usable pre-period series sit at or above it and 15 below, so the no-surge estimates rest on the smaller stratum. SI, *Protest-Intensity Statistic* (S_c) *Construction*, gives the full construction and the distribution.

TABLE 1. Full-sample triple-difference estimates of own-zone police-violence exposure.

Outcome	Effect in 2019 (SE)	p	Pre-trend p	Obs.	Respondents	Zones (treated)
<i>A. Municipalities where protest did not surge: treatment DiD</i>						
Political trust: low share	0.187 (0.062)	0.003	0.584	9,962	3,169	748 (123)
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	0.201 (0.066)	0.002	0.619	9,676	3,114	747 (123)
Police trust: level	-0.130 (0.191)	0.495	0.535	10,170	3,212	749 (123)
Police trust: low share	0.041 (0.087)	0.641	0.450	10,170	3,212	749 (123)
<i>B. High-minus-low protest: DDD contrast</i>						
Political trust: low share	-0.171 (0.067)	0.011	0.455	9,962	3,169	748 (123)
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	-0.230 (0.073)	0.002	0.946	9,676	3,114	747 (123)
Police trust: level	0.260 (0.206)	0.207	0.544	10,170	3,212	749 (123)
Police trust: low share	-0.079 (0.091)	0.384	0.795	10,170	3,212	749 (123)
<i>C. Municipalities that surged: implied treatment DiD</i>						
Political trust: low share	0.016 (0.025)	0.508	0.749	9,962	3,169	748 (123)
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	-0.029 (0.031)	0.340	0.482	9,676	3,114	747 (123)
Police trust: level	0.130 (0.077)	0.094	0.859	10,170	3,212	749 (123)
Police trust: low share	-0.039 (0.027)	0.157	0.667	10,170	3,212	749 (123)

Note: $S_c < 1$ is the no-surge group, $S_c \geq 1$ the surge group; Panel B is their DiD contrast, Panel C the implied surge effect (delta-method SE). Democratic dissatisfaction uses the protocol-selected baseline-outcome specification; other outcomes use the unadjusted DDD. Respondent and municipality-by-wave fixed effects, 2018 omitted, p two-sided, SEs clustered by zone.

FIGURE 2. Exposure Effects by Year, 2016–2019

Note: Treatment-year coefficients for no-surge municipalities ($S < 1$), estimated as the reference group in the full-sample DDD. Red line: estallido onset (2019-10-18). The three share outcomes share one vertical scale (± 0.40) and can be compared directly; police trust: level is a coefficient on the raw 1-5 item, a different unit, and carries its own scale.

$p = .003$) and the share dissatisfied with democracy by 0.201 (SE 0.066, $p = .002$). Figure 2 plots the year-by-year coefficients behind those estimates. Neither measure of police trust moves detectably, a null we interpret below. The high-minus-low difference runs the other way on both outcomes, -0.171 (SE 0.067, $p = .011$) for political distrust and -0.230 (SE 0.073, $p = .002$) for dissatisfaction, very nearly canceling the first. Adding the two leaves an implied effect in the municipalities that surged of 0.016 (SE 0.025, $p = .508$) and -0.029 (SE 0.031, $p = .340$), neither distinguishable from zero. The pre-trend column of Table 1 tests each row's own pre-period coefficients. The protocol described above tests all of them jointly. Dissatisfaction is the one outcome to cross its trigger, at a joint $p = .179$. Its reported estimate therefore uses the baseline-adjusted specification, which raises that value to $p = .659$, while political trust clears the unadjusted joint test on its own at $p = .799$.

The census-zone boundary that defines exposure is one defensible line among several, and if these estimates turned on where exactly it falls, redrawing it should move them. We refit the model with four alternative definitions, built from the same geocoded events and the same timing rule. Three of them count an event within 500, 1,000, or 1,500 meters of the respondent's zone centroid. The fourth counts adjacency instead of distance. Both effects keep their sign and roughly the same magnitude throughout. The institutional-trust effect runs from 0.187 in the own zone to 0.118 under the widest line, and dissatisfaction from 0.201 to 0.136; every high-minus-low difference stays negative. What they lose is precision. Under the 1,500-meter definition, 1,970 of 3,169 respondents count as exposed. The comparison group then consists largely of people who merely live further from an event, and both estimates fall just short of conventional levels ($p = .051$ and $p = .056$). The estimates get smaller because the two groups being compared become more alike.

Attitudes toward police violence polarize along political lines, and Study 1 found exactly this structure. We therefore test the same moderation here with whether a respondent voted for the government whose police carried out the repression. Who a respondent voted for in 2017 conditions how much of this they register. Table 2 reports that, among those who did not vote for the incumbent President, right-wing Piñera, exposure moves police trust by -0.544 (SE 0.327), and, among those who did, it moves it by $+0.526$ (SE 0.354). The difference between those two responses is 1.070 (SE 0.433, $p = .016$), the one subgroup contrast in this study that separates cleanly. Splitting instead by left-right

self-placement divides the sample into a smaller size and points the same way, but reaches conventional levels in neither arm—which is what a smaller and noisier division of the same sample would be expected to do. The repression occurred in the zones where these respondents live, and yet those who voted for the government that ordered the police into the streets did not lower their trust in that police, and if anything raised it, while their neighbors who voted otherwise revised downward. Voting for the government appears to convert into loyalty, making police violence go from evidence against the police into something closer to vindication of them, and it does so even for citizens standing at the site of the abuse.

TABLE 2. Effect in 2019 by 2017 Vote: Sebastián Piñera versus Any Other First-Round Candidate

Outcome	Not-Piñera		Piñera		Difference (SE)	p (difference)
	effect (SE)	N	effect (SE)	N		
Political trust: low share	0.278 (0.088)	128	0.026 (0.178)	123	-0.252 (0.212)	0.239
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	0.348 (0.125)	127	0.086 (0.261)	117	-0.262 (0.254)	0.305
Police trust: level	-0.544 (0.327)	127	0.526 (0.354)	124	1.070 (0.433)	0.016
Police trust: low share	0.149 (0.142)	127	-0.066 (0.164)	124	-0.215 (0.164)	0.194

Note: Effect is the treatment-by-2019 effect within each arm. The Piñera effect is the not-Piñera effect plus the difference, with its standard error from the coefficients' joint covariance. Difference is the vote-by-treatment interaction, with its own p-value. Pooled triple-interaction specification with respondent and municipality-by-wave fixed effects. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on the census zone. Respondents with no recorded 2017 first-round vote are dropped.

That buffering points to why police trust does not move in the main comparison. Trust in the Carabineros collapsed everywhere, not only where violations were documented. Among respondents observed in both 2018 and 2019, the share placing themselves at the floor of the police trust item rose from 11.9% to 28.4% in exposed zones. In unexposed zones, it rose from 9.8% to 24.0%. The raw change among unexposed respondents was -0.501 scale points, and a municipality-by-year term absorbs exactly that kind of common movement. A nationally televised institutional failure leaves little room for local violence exposure to influence perceptions of the police. Democratic satisfaction and trust in political institutions had no comparable national collapse, so proximity to a violation still registers there.

Cluster-robust inference depends on how much independent variation the design actually has, so we test what our own procedure does under the null by permuting treatment across zones within municipalities, and report the results in the SI⁹. Read with those diagnostics, Study 2 shows that living

⁹SI, *Statistical Power and Minimum Detectable Effects*. The exercise re-randomizes exposure within municipalities

where the state used violence erodes confidence in democratic institutions. It does so independently of the national reassessment of the police that ran alongside it.

STUDY 3: CROSS-NATIONAL EVIDENCE

Studies 1 and 2 estimate the effect of exposure to police violence within single countries. In Study 3, we address whether this pattern generalizes across Latin America. To assess the extent of the association, we use the 2008 wave of LAPOP. It is the only cross-national wave ever fielded in the region that asks respondents both our dependent variables of interest and whether the police mistreated them: “In the past 12 months, has any police officer mistreated you verbally, physically, or assaulted you? How many times?”¹⁰. The item records direct exposure reported by the respondent, which differs from the exposures we examined in the previous studies. That difference, and the cross-sectional design, are why we read what follows as corroboration of the pattern rather than as a replication of the effect.

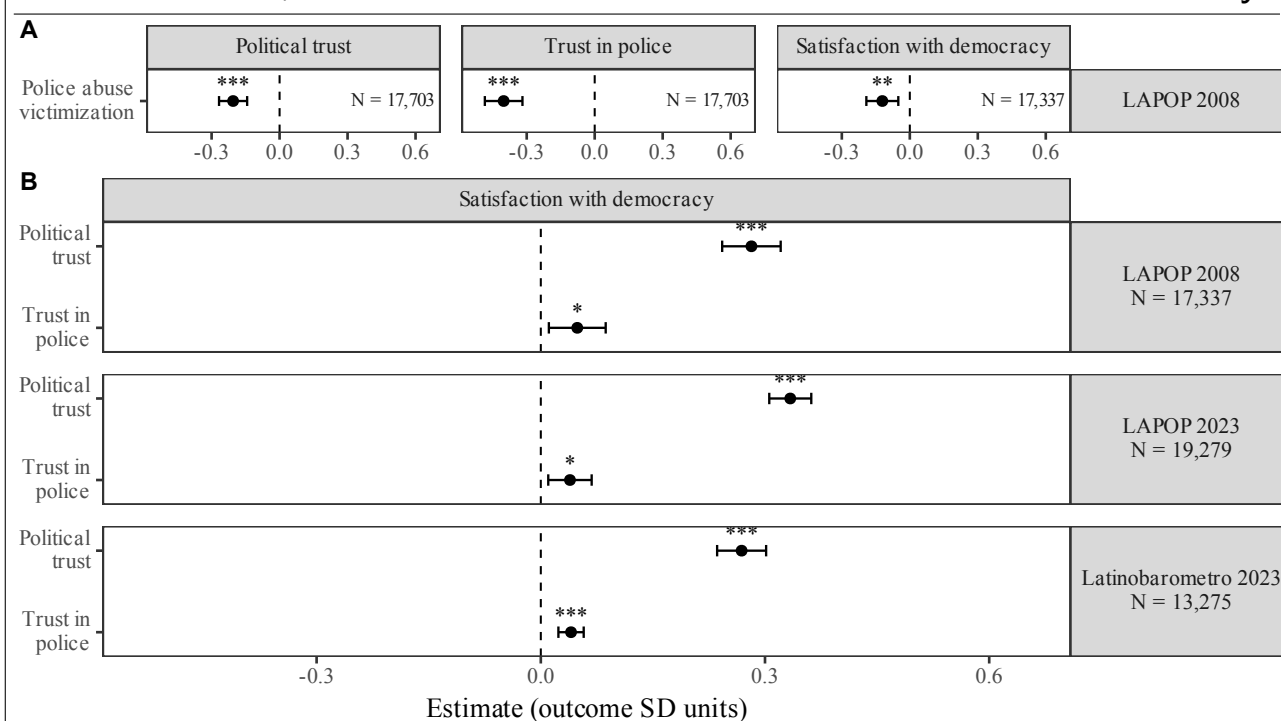
Exposure here is neither assigned nor quasi-random, and the people the police mistreat are not a random draw of respondents. We therefore control for two available rival exposures, as well as multiple other covariates. Crime victimization is included so that the estimate does not simply track who encounters crime, and police bribe solicitation so that it does not track who encounters corrupt officials. Demographic and socioeconomic covariates enter alongside them. We estimate a survey-weighted linear multilevel regression for each outcome. Each country receives its own intercept and its own slope on victimization; the controls enter with one slope shared across countries.

and reports the rejection rate and the minimum detectable effect for every quantity in Table 1. A treated-cluster count is not a count of the information the design carries. Residual intra-zone correlation in the estimating equation is near zero once the fixed effects are in, so the design effect is essentially one and the effective sample is the 9,962 respondent-waves themselves; clustering on the zone in fact yields a smaller standard error than its heteroskedasticity-robust alternative on three of the four outcomes, this one included. The triple difference is estimated across 748 census zones, 123 of them exposed, in 89 municipalities, while the no-surge stratum’s own difference-in-differences rests on 13 treated zones.

¹⁰The item was asked of all respondents, with “don’t-know” responses coded to missing. The item records a count; we code victimization as one or more incidents.

The three outcomes are, again, trust in the police, political trust, and satisfaction with democracy. Trust in police is a single seven-point item. Political trust is a three-item index combining confidence in the legislature, the executive, and the courts; we rescale each item to run from 0 to 1, add them, and standardize the sum. Satisfaction with democracy is a four-point item. We standardize every outcome within the dataset, so a coefficient gives the change in outcome standard deviations for a respondent who reports abuse relative to one who does not.

FIGURE 3. Police Abuse, Trust, and Satisfaction with Democracy. Panel A: victimization and each outcome, LAPOP 2008. Panel B: trust and satisfaction across three surveys.



Note: All estimates use survey weights, and outcomes are standardised within dataset, so coefficients are in outcome standard deviations. Every row comes from a multilevel model that gives each country its own intercept and its own slope on the predictor of interest. Bars are 95% confidence intervals. Stars mark * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. All three datasets cover the same sixteen countries. The SI reports estimation details and full coefficients.

Respondents who report police abuse show lower trust in police, lower political trust, and lower satisfaction with democracy (Figure 3, Panel A). The drop is largest for trust in the police, at -0.402 (SE 0.042 , $p < .001$), but it also appears for the legislature, the executive, and the courts taken together, at -0.205 (SE 0.032 , $p < .001$), and for satisfaction with democracy, at -0.121 (SE 0.036 , $p = .006$). The association is negative in all sixteen countries on both trust measures. In the units respondents

answered in, reporting abuse corresponds to about three-quarters of a point of trust in the police on its seven-point scale, and to under a tenth of a point of satisfaction with democracy on its four-point scale; 5.8 percent of respondents report abuse.

All evidence found so far implies the spillover effect we theorize. A violent encounter is information not only about this one agency, but about the fairness and trustworthiness of the state that arms and authorizes it, and because the police are the institution of that state most present in daily life, the judgment travels from them to the abstract national institutions charged with equality before the law. Trust is where that judgment registers, and satisfaction with democracy is where it surfaces, as a verdict on how the system works in practice. Read this way, the pathway makes two specific claims: that abuse depresses trust in the police and, with it, trust in broader institutions, and that this broader institutional distrust carries through to dissatisfaction with democracy.

Therefore, next, we ask whether the steps from trust to satisfaction with democracy that this mechanism requires are present in the available datasets. In Figure 3, Panel B, we report these steps. With the 2008 LAPOP, fitting the trust-to-satisfaction specification, with controls, political trust predicts satisfaction with democracy at 0.282 (SE 0.020, $p < .001$) per standard deviation of trust, roughly twice the size of the victimization coefficient on the same outcome. We explore two 2023 surveys that reproduce this fifteen years later and find that political trust enters at 0.269 (SE 0.017, $p < .001$) in the Latinobarómetro and 0.334 (SE 0.014, $p < .001$) in LAPOP, trust in police at 0.040 (SE 0.009, $p < .001$) and 0.039 (SE 0.015, $p = .019$). Political trust is the far stronger predictor, and its slope is positive in all sixteen countries of both 2023 surveys. The police trust slope is positive in all sixteen Latinobarómetro countries and in fourteen of the sixteen LAPOP countries, and the two exceptions sit near zero.

The two trust measures are recorded at the same moment, so rather than assume a mediation order, we fit either ordering and present the results in Table 3. If we treat trust in police as the upstream predictor, most of its association with democratic satisfaction runs through political trust: 79.2% in LAPOP 2023 and 67.2% in the Latinobarómetro 2023. Alternatively, almost none of political trust's association runs through trust in police: 5.8% in both.¹¹

¹¹We note that the two trust measures are not statistically independent. Corrected for measurement error, they correlate at .52 to .55, and a single component accounts for 52 percent of their variance, past the level at which

On LAPOP 2008, where the exposure is abuse rather than trust, the decomposition separates the two channels, and both orderings put the route through political trust. Reading political trust as the first mediator, 47.0% of abuse's association with satisfaction runs through it alone against 11.3% through trust in police alone, with 4.4% through both in series and 37.2% direct. Reading trust in police first, its association reaches satisfaction almost entirely by passing into political trust, 48.0% serially against 15.6% through trust in police alone.

TABLE 3. The mediation decomposition, both orderings, all three datasets.

Ordering	Direct	Indirect	Total	% mediated	E-value	Benchmark RR
<i>LAPOP 2008</i>						
A: abuse → police → institutional → satisfaction	-0.044	-0.077**	-0.121**		1.292	1.061
via trust in police alone		-0.019**		15.6%		
via both in series		-0.058**		48.0%		
via political trust alone	0.001			-0.8%		
direct, net of both	-0.045			37.2%		
B: abuse → institutional → police → satisfaction	-0.059	-0.062**	-0.121**		1.292	1.061
via political trust alone		-0.057**		47.0%		
via both in series		-0.005**		4.4%		
via trust in police alone	-0.014**			11.3%		
direct, net of both	-0.045			37.2%		
<i>LAPOP 2023</i>						
A: police → institutional → satisfaction	0.039**	0.148**	0.187**	79.2%	2.216	1.134
B: institutional → police → satisfaction	0.334**	0.020**	0.354**	5.8%	1.254	1.134
<i>Latinobarómetro 2023</i>						
A: police → institutional → satisfaction	0.040**	0.083**	0.123**	67.2%	2.037	1.346
B: institutional → police → satisfaction	0.269**	0.017**	0.285**	5.8%	1.266	1.346
<i>Note:</i> 95% CIs from a 1,000-resample bootstrap over countries. Stars: *** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$. For the 2023 panels, which carry one mediator, % mediated is the indirect share of the total. The LAPOP 2008 panel has two mediators, so the rows indented beneath each ordering decompose it instead: each component's estimate sits under the Direct or Indirect column it belongs to, the parent cell is the sum of its two indented entries, and the four shares sum to 100%. Indirect is everything passing through the first-named mediator; the bootstrap intervals and stars are computed per row from the same replicates, components included. Each country's own indirect effect is negative – the direction the pathway predicts, since LAPOP 2008's exposure is police abuse rather than trust – in 16/16 (A) and 16/16 (B) in LAPOP 2008; positive in 16/16 (A) and 14/16 (B) in LAPOP 2023, and 16/16 (A) and 15/16 (B) in Latinobarómetro. E-value is the smaller of the two links', since a mediated effect resists confounding only as well as its weaker link. Benchmark RR is the strongest association any measured covariate has with the outcome, as $\max(RR, 1/RR)$; an E-value above it means the confounder would have to beat every covariate we measured.						

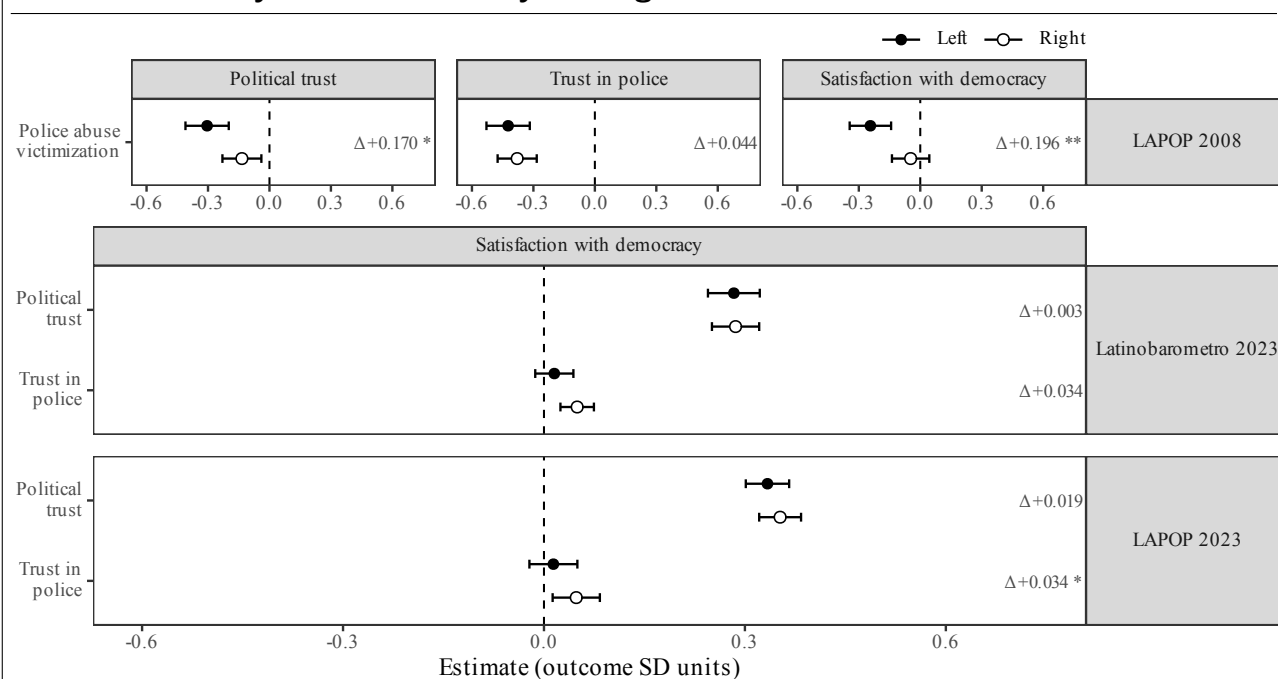
Three robustness checks suggest this pattern is not an artifact of model specification. First, adding the two trust measures increases the explained variance from 0.190 to 0.269 in the Latinobarómetro, constructs are conventionally treated as separable. Although our analysis suggests political trust carries the direct, cross-sectional association, and trust in police reaches satisfaction with democracy mainly through it, these measures are recorded at the same time. Thus, this is not a definitive test of mediation, and we present these results as descriptive.

and from 0.084 to 0.208 in LAPOP. Second, political trust's coefficient declines only modestly (from 0.268 to 0.219) when controlling for winner–loser status, corruption perceptions, and presidential approval, suggesting it is not simply a proxy for other regime judgments. Third, any unmeasured confounder would need to be strongly associated with both trust and satisfaction to explain away the observed effect. We calculate the necessary threshold using the E-value (VanderWeele and Ding 2017), which is 2.04 in one survey and 2.22 in the other, whereas the strongest measured variable reaches only 1.35. For trust in police, the threshold is lower (1.27 and 1.25). This aligns with the decomposition: a measure whose association with satisfaction operates primarily through another variable should be more sensitive to confounding. Taken together, these results indicate that political trust is the more direct conduit for the effect of police violence on satisfaction with democracy, with trust in the police influencing this judgment more indirectly.

We also probe whether these associations vary by ideology and by race, mirroring Study 1's moderators as far as these surveys allow. As reported in Figure 4, among left-identified respondents, reporting abuse corresponds to -0.304 (SE 0.054) on political trust and -0.243 (SE 0.052) on satisfaction with democracy, against -0.135 (SE 0.049) and -0.047 (SE 0.047) among right-identified respondents, with $p = .013$ and $p = .004$ for the differences; the police trust association does not differ by ideology ($p = .517$).

Here the respondents are reporting abuse against themselves, and ideology still conditions what they conclude from it. A left-identified victim reads the abuse as an indictment of the political system, revising political trust and satisfaction with democracy downward, while a right-identified victim largely contains the experience, registering it against the police at most and leaving the regime evaluations nearly untouched. Personal experience, the hardest information a citizen can receive, does not override the political lens. In the 2023 surveys, the police trust slope on satisfaction is somewhat larger on the right (difference $p = .023$ in LAPOP, $p = .056$ in the Latinobarómetro), while the political trust slope does not differ. None of the seven white versus non-white differences is distinguishable from zero (p between .22 and .83). The full moderation tables are in the SI.

We run the same nine robustness checks on all three datasets. They include alternative definitions of the trust index, ordinal rather than linear outcome models, and E-value sensitivity. Refitting every

FIGURE 4. Study 3 Associations by Ideological Self-Placement

Note: Drawn in two blocks, which carry different outcomes: the upper gives the LAPOP 2008 police-abuse associations, the lower the 2023 trust-to-satisfaction ones. Predictors run down the left, outcomes across the top, and the dataset is given at the right. Each cell shows both groups as a filled and an open mark with 95% confidence intervals. Δ is the difference between the two groups, right minus left, and * marks $p < .05$ on that difference, not on the individual associations. Both blocks share one horizontal scale.

model with country dummies and standard errors clustered on country—which assumes nothing about how countries are distributed—leaves every coefficient within a hundredth of its reported value, changes no sign and no standing against zero, and returns errors slightly smaller than the multilevel ones, so the intervals we report are the wider of the two. For the 2008 analysis we additionally re-estimate all three associations by weighting rather than regression adjustment—propensity, entropy-balancing and doubly robust schemes that equalize the covariate distributions of victimized and non-victimized respondents, each screened on overlap and balance before its estimate is read—and every scheme that clears that screen reproduces the reported coefficients without assuming that the controls enter linearly. The SI reports all of them, with country-level diagnostics and complete estimates for every equation.

DISCUSSION

The three studies return the same answer to the paper’s question: citizens in our settings did not treat their evaluation of the police as separate from their evaluation of the regime. When the police turned violent, respondents marked down institutions that had no part in the encounter, along with their satisfaction with democracy itself. This runs against a common expectation, in which diffuse support is buffered against complaints about the day-to-day performance of individual agencies, and that buffering helps explain why democracies remain stable when particular institutions disappoint. Whatever protection the buffer affords elsewhere, we find none of it where the police are concerned; in all three studies, evaluations of the police entered judgements about the system itself. Table 4 summarizes how the three designs reach that conclusion.

Each study, taken alone, is open to an objection, and the objections do not overlap. The Brazilian experiment assigns exposure at random, but because the exposure is a written scenario it cannot tell us what happens when a person is actually harmed. The Chilean panel captures real repression, but where protest surged we cannot separate a genuinely absent effect from exposure so widespread that no untreated neighbor remains. The cross-national study reaches sixteen countries and respondents’ own victimization, but it is observational, and no set of controls can reconstruct the counterfactual that a causal claim requires. Had the three designs shared a weakness, their agreement would mean little, since the same flaw could have produced the same wrong answer three times. Because the weaknesses

TABLE 4. How the three studies triangulate the same conclusion.

	Exposure	Population	Quantity estimated	Contributes
Study 1	Written scenario of a violent police stop	Brazilian adults, on-line panel	Randomized effect of indirect exposure	Internal validity
Study 2	Documented repression in the respondent's census zone	Chilean panel respondents, 2016–2019	Difference-in-differences effect of local exposure	Ecological validity
Study 3	Personal victimization reported by the respondent	LAPOP respondents in sixteen countries	Covariate-adjusted association	External validity

Note: Every estimated effect or association on police trust, political trust, and satisfaction with democracy is negative in all three studies. Specifications, samples, and estimates appear in the study sections and the SI.

differ, a skeptical reading of the pattern requires three unrelated failures to have pointed the same way at once. Nor did we expect the designs to produce comparable magnitudes, since they measure different exposures in different populations with different instruments. The prediction common to all three was directional, and that prediction held in each case.

The moderation results bear on the process behind these effects, and they distinguish exposure at a distance from exposure in person. Trust in the police, the judgement closest to the event, is the clearest case. Where exposure was indirect, the response depended on identity and prior politics: in Brazil the vignette moved pro-PT, non-white, and high-aggression respondents furthest, while in Chile the one clean subgroup contrast divides residents by their vote for the president whose government commanded the repression. Direct victimization follows a different pattern, in which victims on the left and on the right lost trust in the police at similar rates; because the cross-national sample is by far our largest, that null cannot be attributed to thin data. We read the contrast as evidence about interpretation. A person the police mistreated has little need of prior beliefs to understand what happened, whereas a person hearing about violence at a distance must decide what to make of it. Prior beliefs reappear one step further on, since among direct victims ideology does moderate how far the damage extends to political trust and to satisfaction with democracy. Victims' politics shaped how far the experience generalized to the regime rather than their view of the police who harmed them.

The political pattern also has an implication for measurement. In both countries where a political moderator was available, the respondents who buffered their view of the police were those aligned with the side that champions them. In Chile, Piñera voters' trust in the police survived exposure that lowered

it among everyone else; in Brazil, the vignette moved anti-PT respondents about half as far as their pro-PT counterparts. Trust in the police is usually read as an evaluation of performance, but on this evidence part of what it records is political loyalty. Because the item is a standard fixture of comparative surveys, analyses that treat it purely as a performance measure will absorb some political sorting into what they report as assessments of policing. Two mechanisms could produce the alignment, and our cases cannot separate them. Concern over police violence has long belonged to the Latin American left, so the pattern may follow the left whoever governs. Alternatively, it may reflect opposition to the government that commands the police, and in that case it should reverse when the left holds that command. In the periods we study, the salient champions of the police sat on the right, and the two mechanisms therefore predict the same observations.

These results support a bounded claim: exposure to police violence worsens citizens' evaluations of democratic institutions, in the same direction in every setting we examined. They do not support comparisons of magnitude across the three studies, whose different exposures and instruments make the estimates non-commensurable. Nor do they support conclusions about policy, since no design here estimates the consequences of any particular reform, or a prediction about the partisan moderator under a government of the left, for the reason given above.

The paper's contribution is to move police violence from the study of policing into the study of democracy. Measured only by attitudes toward the police, misconduct appears to be a problem for one agency and its reformers. In our results, the damage extends to the institutions of the regime itself, under three kinds of exposure and in settings that range from a single national panel to a sixteen-country survey. A question follows that our designs were not built to pursue: which institutional arrangements weaken the connection between police conduct and system legitimacy. Political systems plausibly differ in how well they absorb shocks of this kind, and identifying the sources of that difference is the natural extension of these results.

CONCLUSION

This paper asked whether police violence damages the attitudes that sustain democracy. Three studies varied the exposure: a randomized vignette in Brazil, geocoded repression during Chile's *estallido*

social, and self-reported victimization across sixteen Latin American countries. In all three, exposure lowered satisfaction with democracy; trust in political institutions fell in the Chilean and cross-national studies, and in Brazil among the groups the moderators identify. The political damage varied with partisanship in Brazil and in the cross-national data, and with identity where exposure was indirect.

Latin American politicians repeatedly offer *mano dura* policing as the remedy for crime. Our results record a cost that rarely enters that debate: police violence weakens public attachment to democratic institutions. The cost is also unlikely to fall evenly. In Brazil and in the cross-national data, the political damage was larger among citizens on the left, and in the experiment it further concentrated among non-whites and among the dispositionally aggressive, the group most primed to register abuse. Supporters of the side that champions the police registered less of it: in Chile their trust in the police survived exposure outright, and in Brazil the treatment left anti-PT respondents' political trust unmoved. Police violence may therefore do more than lower average support for the system. It can sort disaffection along political cleavages the region already contends with, concentrating doubts about the regime in the groups that prior work identifies as the most exposed to the state's coercion and the most critical of it. Debates over iron-fist policing are typically framed around whether it reduces crime. On our evidence, what the accompanying police violence does to citizens' confidence in democratic institutions belongs in that debate as well.

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